

Breaking new ground on ice

Tara Prasad on pursuing her Olympic dreams while balancing her passions and **promoting** winter sports.

Rajdeep Saha

rajdeep.saha@thehindu.co.in



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Tara Prasad was seven when she first stepped onto the ice. For the next decade, figure skating remained nothing more than a recreational pursuit. Today, at 25, she proudly represents India on the sport's biggest stages.

"There's obviously a more serious aspect now than when I was a kid. But sometimes, if I'm at an outdoor rink or it's just one of those random days, when I get on the ice and skate for fun, that same feeling is still there," Tara tells *Sportstar*, reflecting on her journey months after making her debut at the Winter Asian Games this year. She finished a creditable eighth out of 24 finalists in Harbin, China.

Tara comes from a family of athletes. Call it serendipity or not, her mother, Kavitha Ramasamy, was also seven when she first found her calling — in athletics. Kavitha, whose 87-year-old father, V. Ramasamy, still competes in Masters athletics events, admits she'd choose hurdling or long-distance running over putting on a pair of skates any day.

"Skating isn't just about going to the rink. There's nutrition, conditioning, massage therapy — it's the culmination of many sports," says Kavitha, who once trained alongside the legendary P. T. Usha at the 1990 Beijing Asian Games camp. "This is totally different from athletics. I've tried stepping onto the ice, and it's not easy for me."

Go-for-it girl

Born in Iowa, Tara chose to swap her American passport for an Indian one in 2019.

The decision, however, wasn't driven by sporting ambitions — in fact, she had none at the time.

"At that point in my life, I wasn't serious about sports. The change was because I wanted to settle in India for good. I had no intention of getting on Team USA either — skating was just something I did for fun. It was only after I took a long sabbatical and came back to skating that I considered pursuing it seriously. By then, I already had an Indian passport," she recalls.

That break came between the ages of 16 and 20, when academics took priority over sports. Though she continued to follow the sport from a distance, it was the dream of competing in major championships — and believing she could — that eventually drew her back to the ice.

Her mother calls her a 'go-for-it girl'.

"If she decides to do something, she won't give up easily. She's very creative, and it's hard to understand her mind because it works so fast [laughs]," says Kavitha. Not stubborn — just determined, maybe. That determination shone through during one of Tara's toughest challenges: battling Postural Orthostatic Tachycardia Syndrome (POTS).

"I was fainting a lot. It cost me a season. That's why, last year, I started competing later than everyone else — I had to take a long break," Tara says.

Since adopting Indian citizenship, Tara has earned considerable media coverage back home, including praise on social media from industrialist Anand Mahindra.

But fame brought its own set of challenges. "After the Asian Games and the Four Continents Championships, when I got a bit of public attention, there was also a rise in online